

LOGISTICS COSTS

LATEST INSIGHTS ON TRANSPORTATION TRENDS AND TRADE RESILIENCE

2025
REPORT



Key Metrics & Trends

Over the last five years, logistics costs across Western Canada have shown sharp and often unpredictable year-over-year swings — especially since 2020. These fluctuations reflect a mix of global and local stressors: fuel price volatility, pandemic-era disruptions, labor shortages, and infrastructure bottlenecks have all contributed to compounding cost pressures across supply chains.

In Calgary's case, transportation data from rail yards to refineries reveals how local corridors absorb and respond to these shocks. While some cost increases are short-term spikes, others reflect deeper structural changes — such as sustained shifts in freight demand, modal rebalancing between trucking and rail, or tighter cross-border regulations.

These insights do more than quantify cost: they signal how resilient or vulnerable different sectors are to global trends. For example, rising trucking costs may correlate with long-haul driver shortages or supply-chain rerouting, while port fees or demurrage charges might point to container congestion or misaligned inventory planning.

What emerges is a pattern: logistics costs act as a lagging but powerful indicator of systemic stress. By analyzing these shifts, stakeholders can build smarter forecasts, justify investment in redundancy or automation, and calibrate their procurement and production strategies with greater precision.

Strategic Insights from the Data

Canadian logistics costs serve as more than just operational expenses — they are **forward-looking barometers** of economic health, infrastructure integrity, and supply chain resilience. When freight rates shift, it's rarely random. Often, they signal a deeper transformation in how goods move, where demand is concentrated, and where vulnerabilities exist.

In Calgary's case, this is especially important. As a central node in Canada's export engine — connecting farms, factories, refineries, and railyards to domestic and global markets — logistics data from this region provides **early-warning signals**. Rising costs may reflect truck driver shortages, port congestion, rail inefficiencies, or policy changes on emissions and carbon pricing. Conversely, declining costs might suggest increased modal efficiency, slack in demand, or successful diversification of supply lines.

These patterns matter. They offer insight into everything from **food security risk** (if fertilizer imports slow or grain exports bottleneck), to **energy resilience** (if crude oil or refined product shipments are delayed), to **urban infrastructure planning** (if congestion and last-mile costs spike around distribution zones).

More importantly, logistics costs help **connect the dots between micro disruptions and macro strategy**. For example, a 12% spike in container rates may reflect localized delays — or it may be an indicator of systemic underinvestment in warehousing, rail switching capacity, or labor mobility. Understanding the **why** behind these shifts is what turns raw metrics into real foresight.

That's why our dashboard doesn't just track data — it **interprets the narrative** behind it. When policymakers, exporters, and investors can read these cost curves in context, they gain the power to anticipate chokepoints before they crystallize. And in an era where **volatility is the new normal**, this kind of insight is not a luxury — it's a necessity.

Logistics costs are a mirror of the real economy — when they shift, something deeper is happening.

These shifts impact everything from producer margins and export timing to infrastructure investment and global competitiveness.

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13%

*Year-over-year spike in freight costs across key
Alberta corridors.*

This figure is a proxy for broader logistical strain — signaling that inflationary transport inputs are increasingly tied to structural risks, not just temporary shocks. Such cost surges can be early indicators of growing trade fragmentation, declining infrastructure efficiency, or insufficient contingency planning. Stakeholders should treat these fluctuations as both signals and symptoms — prompting preemptive rather than reactive strategy.

Logistics Costs Are a Barometer

This visual illustrates a stylized trend to help audiences quickly grasp how freight costs may shift over time. While not based on specific numbers, it signals disruptions like fuel volatility, supply chain congestion, or export surges.

